SURVEY REPORT

Emerging Trends in Low-Code Application Development

A study of adoption patterns, platform capabilities, and the shift toward AI-assisted, citizen-led software development.

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INTRODUCTION

What Is Low-Code Application Development?

Low-code platforms let developers and non-developers build software through visual, drag-and-drop interfaces and model-driven logic — writing little to no hand-coded syntax. Adoption has accelerated as organizations race to close the gap between growing software demand and limited developer capacity.

This survey report

Synthesizes findings from industry surveys, platform documentation, and adoption data to map how low-code development is evolving in 2025–2026.

70%

of new enterprise apps projected to use low-code / no-code tools by 2026

4x

faster average time-to-delivery vs. traditional hand-coded development

3 in 4

large organizations now using at least one low-code platform

METHODOLOGY

Survey Objectives & Methodology

1

Identify Key Trends

Pinpoint the technology and process shifts reshaping low-code platforms today.

2

Assess Adoption Drivers

Understand why organizations and citizen developers are turning to low-code.

3

Evaluate Challenges

Surface governance, security, and scalability concerns raised by practitioners.

4

Forecast Direction

Project where low-code development is headed over the next 2–3 years.

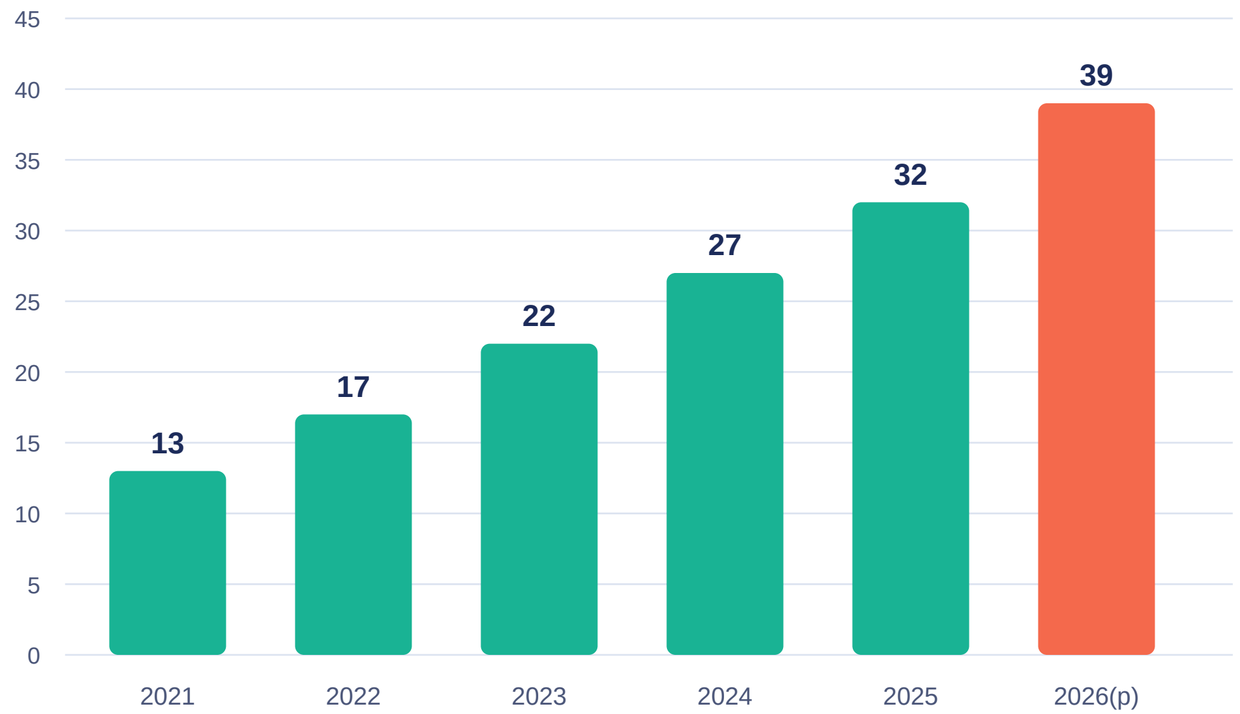
Approach

Findings draw on secondary research across vendor reports, developer-community surveys, and analyst commentary covering low-code / no-code platforms, comparing responses from IT leaders, professional developers, and citizen developers.

MARKET SNAPSHOT

Low-Code Market Growth & Adoption

Global low-code platform market revenue ($B), illustrative trend



Why adoption is accelerating

- Persistent shortage of professional developers
- Pressure to modernize legacy systems quickly
- Business units demanding self-service tooling
- Cloud-native platforms lowering entry cost

SECTION

Four Emerging Trends in Low-Code Development

AI augmentation · Citizen development · Enterprise integration · Governance-first design

TREND 01

AI-Augmented Development

AI

Generative AI is now embedded directly into low-code platforms — turning natural-language prompts into working workflows, forms, and data models, and auto-suggesting logic as builders work.

- Prompt-to-app generation for rapid first drafts
- AI copilots suggesting logic, fields, and integrations
- Automated testing and error detection during build
- Natural-language data queries for citizen developers

Why it matters

AI assistance is the most-cited reason developers give for choosing a low-code platform in 2025–26 surveys.

~60%

of platforms surveyed now ship a built-in AI assistant or copilot

TREND 02

Citizen Development & Democratization

CD

Business users with no formal coding background are building and maintaining their own applications, shifting IT's role from sole builder to platform enabler and governor.

IT's New Role

Sets guardrails, approves connectors, and manages shared components instead of building every app.

Fusion Teams

Citizen developers pair with professional developers on higher-stakes, cross-functional projects.

Managed Sprawl

Centralized app catalogs and approval gates keep shadow IT and duplicate apps in check.

TREND 03 & 04

Enterprise Integration & Governance-First Design

IN

Deep Enterprise Integration

- Native connectors to ERP, CRM, and legacy databases
- API-first architecture for headless, multi-experience apps
- Composable modules reused across business units
- Low-code extending, not replacing, core IT systems

GV

Governance-First Design

- Built-in audit trails, versioning, and access controls
- Centralized visibility into all citizen-built apps
- Security and compliance checks enforced pre-deployment
- Platform-level policies to curb shadow-IT risk

SURVEY FINDINGS

Challenges Practitioners Still Report

1. **Vendor Lock-In** — Migrating apps off a proprietary low-code platform remains costly and technically difficult.
2. **Scalability Limits** — Complex, high-volume workloads can outgrow what visual builders handle efficiently.
3. **Shadow IT Risk** — Without governance, citizen-built apps can multiply outside IT's visibility and control.
4. **Skill & Design Gaps** — Citizen developers often lack training in data modeling, security, and UX best practice.

CONCLUSION

Key Takeaways

1. AI is shifting from an add-on to the core interface of low-code platforms.
2. Citizen developers are a permanent, growing part of the delivery workforce.
3. Enterprises are integrating low-code deeply rather than treating it as a silo.
4. Governance and security maturity now determine platform success at scale.